The brief and our reframing

4 September–12 October 2026. We explored how pre-arrival care could help guests feel recognised while keeping the hotel's promises deliverable.

The brief as given

We began with a tension in luxury hospitality: asking about a preference creates an expectation. More questions can multiply combinations of room preparation, timing and service requests, while staff capacity, room changes and cost to serve remain constrained. The brief described an earlier hyper-personalisation pilot that had been stopped because of operational complexity.

We were asked to build engagement and manage expectations after booking and before arrival, without over-promising. The commercial intent was brand equity, loyalty and spending on property. This was not a booking-conversion brief.

The brief as we reframed it

We are solving for pre-arrival care that helps guests feel recognised and can be delivered reliably at manageable cost and complexity, in service of Mandarin Oriental's goal of strengthening brand equity and guests' willingness to pay.

We chose an urban MO context and a high-net-worth guest segment, often represented by a human assistant. The "top 5%" boundary was our design focus, not a verified segment size. We connected what the assistant knows before arrival with what a Dream Maker may notice in person, then asked how both could become an owned, feasible service response.

How the work unfolded

Period	What we worked on
4–7 Sep	Interrogate the brief; separate facts, assumptions and questions; hear Kate's account.
11–19 Sep	Build evidence through fieldwork, MO conversations and assistant interviews; challenge the initial framing.
18–25 Sep	Develop insights, compare concepts, map stakeholders and work through the service journey.
28 Sep–2 Oct	Connect user value to business measures; write criteria and failure conditions.
By 5–12 Oct	Iterate the room prototype and Dream Maker workflow; assemble the final proposition and playback.

The timeline follows dated course and project records. Some workshop artefacts are undated; their exact production day is not inferred.

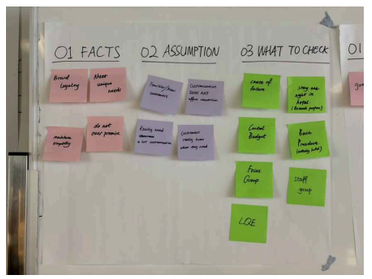


Fig. 1. Our early Facts / Assumptions / Checks wall. The case study follows the work behind the conclusion.